

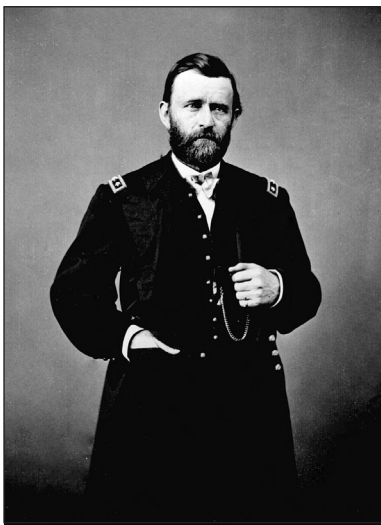
Week 4: The War Begins/Waging War: The Western Theater to Shiloh

Questions

1. What were the critical differences between the Confederacy and the Union, once the war began? What were the key similarities?
2. How did the differences between the Confederacy and the Union shape their preparation for the Civil War?
3. How did the differences between the Confederacy and the Union shape their goals for the war and/or their overall strategy?
4. To what extent did the Battle of Shiloh change the Civil War and views/opinions of the war?

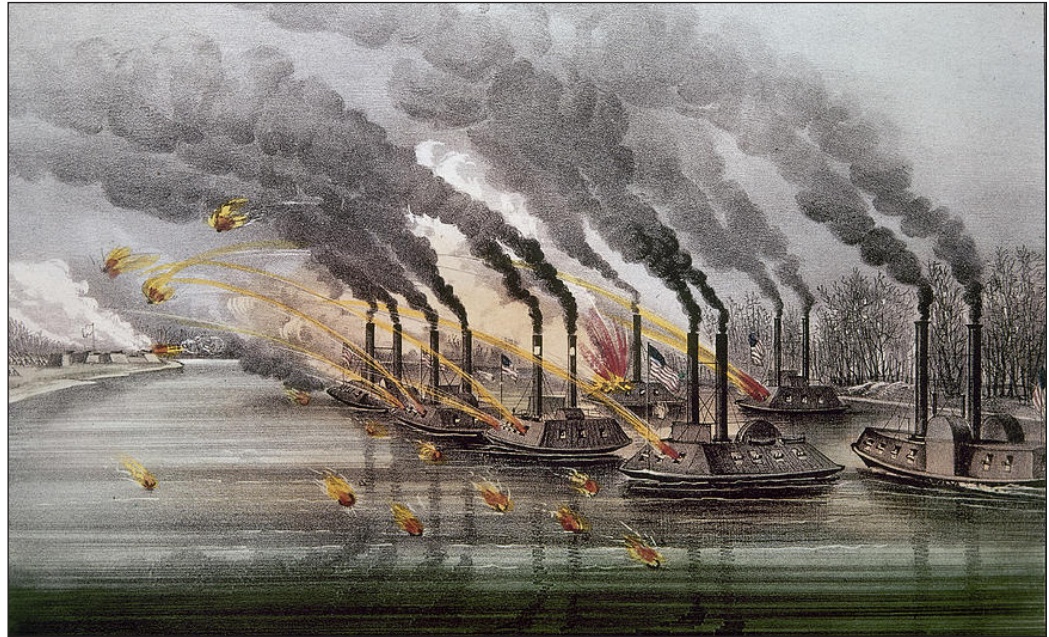
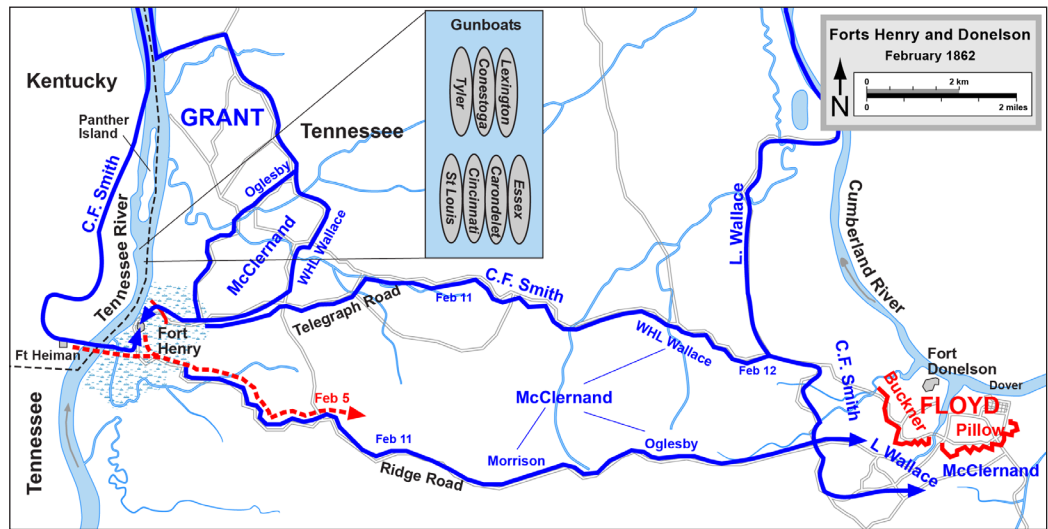
Key Terms

- Fort Donelson
- John E. Richardson
- Eugene Blackford
- Ulysses S. Grant
- The Battle of Shiloh



At the start of the Civil War, Ulysses S. Grant hardly seemed likely to become the North's greatest general. Though West Point-educated, he was an indifferent student and soldier, and by 1860 he had left the army, failed in business, and battled alcoholism. Nonetheless, his tenacity, self-confidence, and willingness to ignore conventional wisdom proved invaluable to President Lincoln, who—after a string of victories—made clear that, “Grant is my man, and I am his, for the rest of the war.”

Forts Henry and Donelson



The Union Army's operations in Tennessee in February 1862 (top) began with the bombardment of Fort Henry (middle, in a print from 1862) and concluded with the capture of Fort Donelson (bottom right, in a print from 1887). The surrender of these two forts gave the North its first major victories of the Civil War and made a hero of Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant. His insistence on an “unconditional and immediate surrender” of Fort Donelson earned him the nickname “Unconditional Surrender” Grant.

Day 1 Timeline

March 1-April 5:

Grant transports Army of west Tennessee (over 58,000 men) into southwest Tennessee; camps at Pittsburg Landing, and awaits Buell's army

March 1:

Johnston transports 55,000 Confederates to Corinth to defend the Memphis and Charleston Railroad

April 3:

Johnston advances toward Pittsburg Landing. Rain and bad roads delay his advance

April 6:

Johnston launches surprise attack on Federals

4:55-6:30 a.m.:

Federal patrol discovers Confederates in Fraley Field. Federals skirmish and fall back.

6:30-9:00 a.m.:

Johnston maneuvers eight brigades to overrun Prentiss's camps, routing the Union division

7:00-10:00 a.m.:

Sherman's division repulses Confederates, inflicting heavy casualties

10:00-11:30 a.m.:

Confederates assault Sherman and McClernand on the Hamburg-Purdy Road, driving back Union right flank

Noon-3:30 p.m.:

Gibson's Confederates assault Federal center three times and are repulsed. Confederates hit by murderous fire in impenetrable oak thicket.

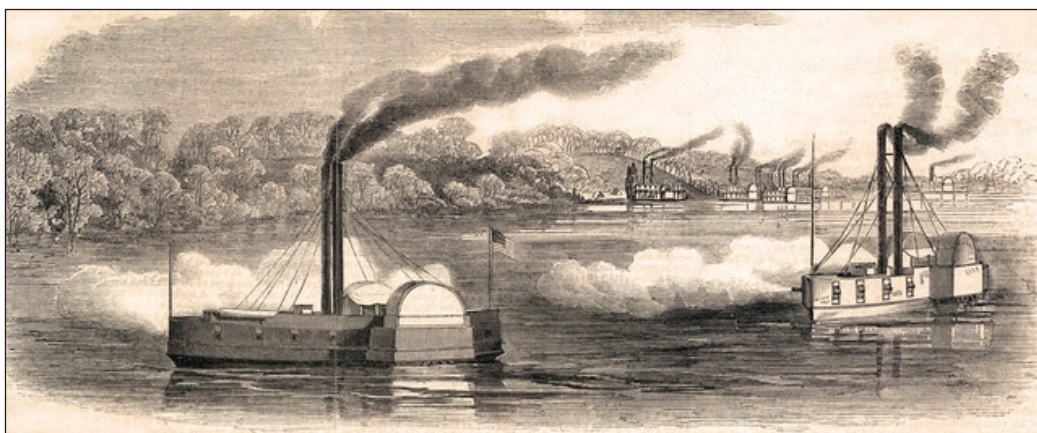
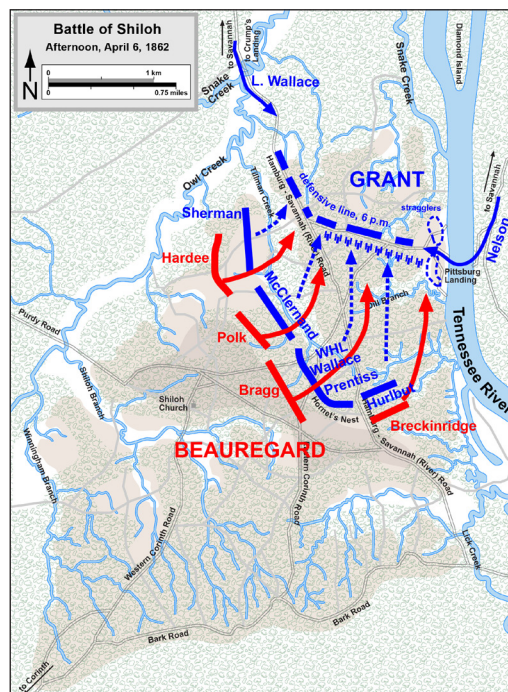
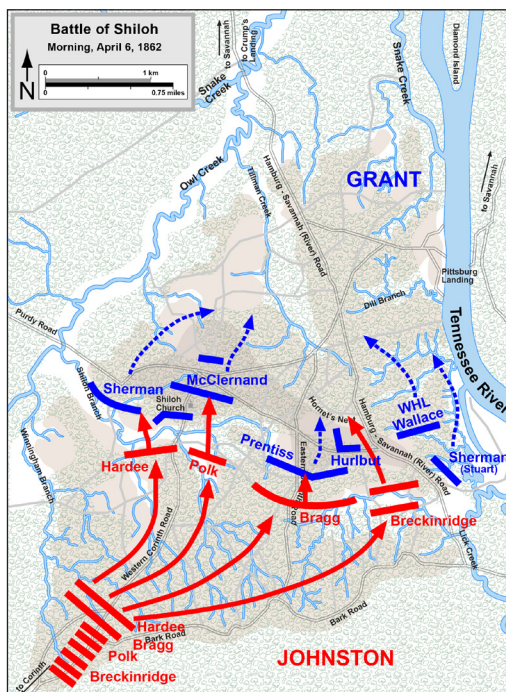
1:00-4:00 p.m.:

Johnston orders attack against Federal left, forcing them back. Johnston killed; succeeded by Beauregard.

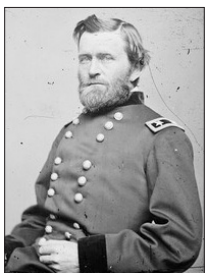
Night:

Buell's troops file in on Union left; Union gunboats bombard Confederate positions

Shiloh, Day 1: April 6, 1862

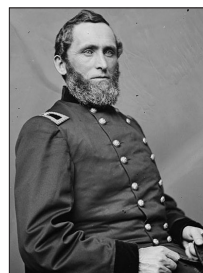


The Battle of Shiloh marked one of the few times during the Civil War that Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant was caught unprepared. In early March of 1862, he established camp at Pittsburg Landing in Tennessee in order to train new recruits and to await the arrival of reinforcements. On April 6, 1862, Confederate Gen. Albert Sidney Johnston launched a surprise attack on Grant's position (top left). This sent the Federal troops scrambling, and though they rallied, they were nonetheless pinned up against the Tennessee River as night fell (top right). Though Johnston was mortally wounded, and despite heavy fire from Union gunboats (bottom, in an 1862 engraving from *Frank Leslie's Illustrated Weekly*), new Confederate commander Gen. P.G.T. Beauregard—expected to finish the job on April 7.



The Union suffered such heavy losses on April 6 that many of Grant's officers expected him to withdraw from the field. When asked if he wanted to prepare for a retreat, Grant answered:

Retreat? No. I propose to attack at daylight and whip them.



Union Brig. Gen. Benjamin Prentiss was captured on the first day of the battle. He told his captors:

You gentlemen have had your way today, but it will be very different tomorrow. You'll see. Buell will effect a junction with Grant tonight and we'll turn the tables on you in the morning. You'll see.

- April 6, 1862

- April 6, 1862

Day 2 Timeline

7:00-9:00 a.m.:

Grant and Buell advance. Skirmishing light as majority of Confederates retired south of Hamburg-Purdy road during night.

9:00-11:00 a.m.:

Nelson advances through Wicker's and Sarah Bell's fields, Crittenden advances in center, but stalled in "hornet's nest"

9:00-11:00 a.m.:

Breckinridge and Hardee counterattack Nelson's right flank and force Federal left back into Wicker's field

9:00-11:00 a.m.:

McCook crosses Tilghman Branch and engages Breckinridge's left

10:30-Noon:

Sherman, McClelland and Hurlbut cross Tilghman Branch and join Wallace in fighting against Polk and Bragg on Confederate left

10:30-Noon:

Confederates flanked by Wallace and forced to retire to Hamburg/Purdy road

Noon-2:00 p.m.:

Reinforced, Nelson and Crittenden advance, forcing Beauregard's right flank to retreat south to Hamburg/Purdy road.

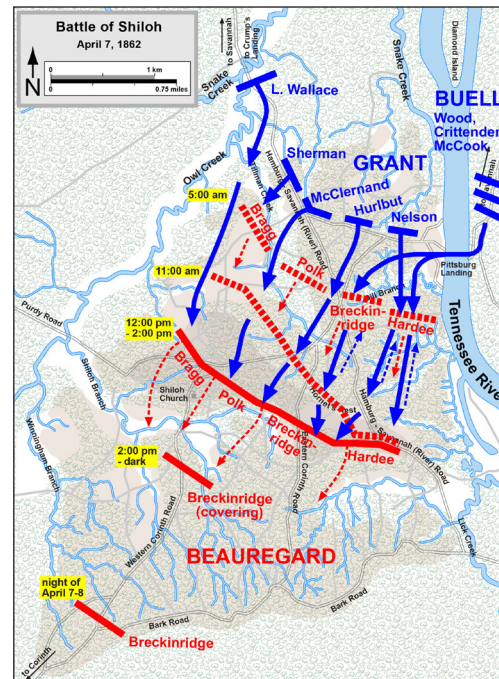
Noon-2:00 p.m.:

McCook slams into Bragg at Water Oak Pond. Beauregard counterattacks, halting McCook. With his left under pressure, Beauregard is forced to retire.

2:00-4:00 p.m.:

Breckinridge, supported by massed artillery south of Shiloh Branch ravine, checks Union advance and Confederates retire from field. Federals reclaim possession of the field.

Shiloh, Day 2: April 7, 1862



Aided by the reinforcements that arrived on the night of April 6, Grant was able to launch a counter-attack early on the morning of April 7 (below, in an 1862 engraving from *Frank Leslie's Illustrated Weekly*). This ultimately culminated in a Confederate retreat and victory for the Union (left).

Shiloh was the first real indication of the Civil War's potential for large-scale carnage, with 13,000 casualties on the Northern side and 10,700 on the Southern. After, grave diggers and orderlies struggled to clear all of the human and animal corpses, as captured in a Frank Leslie's engraving of dead horses being burned for disposal. (below).

I saw an open field...so covered with dead that it would have been possible to walk across the clearing, in any direction, stepping on dead bodies, without a foot touching the ground.

- Ulysses S. Grant on Shiloh, 1862



Major Movements of the Western Theater, 1861-1865

JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
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1861

Wilson's
Creek

First
Lexington

Belmont

1862

GRANT IN TENNESSEE AND MISSISSIPPI

Fort
Henry

Fort
Donelson

Shiloh

Siege of
Corinth

Buell
Halted

GRANT'S VICKSBURG CAMPAIGN

Second
Corinth

Chickasaw
Bayou

UNION OPERATIONS IN THE TRANS-MISSISSIPPI

Pea
Ridge

Capture of
New Orleans

Fleet and land operations against
Vicksburg from New Orleans

BRAGG'S OFFENSIVE

Perryville

Stones River

1863

GRANT'S VICKSBURG CAMPAIGN

Grant tries several approaches
for reaching Vicksburg

River
Crossing

Siege
Begins

Vicksburg
Falls

OPERATIONS AGAINST PORT HUDSON

Operations west
of New Orleans

Siege
Begins

Port Hudson
Falls

CHICKAMAUGA AND CHATTANOOGA CAMPAIGNS

Chickamauga

Lookout Mountain

Missionary Ridge

KNOXVILLE CAMPAIGN

Knoxville
Captured

Confederates'
Siege Raised

1864

SHERMAN'S ATLANTA CAMPAIGN

Rocky Face
Ridge

Kennesaw
Mountain

Hood's
Sorties

Atlanta
Falls

Hood
Counterattacks

March
to the Sea

Savannah
Falls

RED RIVER CAMPAIGN

Sabine
Crossroads

Pleasant
Hill

1865

SHERMAN'S OPERATIONS IN THE CAROLINAS

Columbia

Fayetteville

Bentonville

Goldsboro

Joseph Johnston Surrenders
April 26, 1865